Proactive Chats: next steps and opt-in reminders for Granicus

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Independent case study, not an official Granicus product. Built from public information and my own resident interviews. **Try the prototype:** proactive.abbagani.com, a demo set in Maple Town, a fictional town.

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Objective

The playground is getting a new life as an outdoor gym. But before the neighborhood can open it, there are approvals to secure, equipment to install, and inspections to pass. What happens next, and how do residents know they haven't missed a step?

In my survey of 29 residents, 12 said they'd missed a government step or deadline because they didn't know it existed.

What Granicus does. Granicus runs the websites, email and text updates, and service tools that governments use to reach residents. It says its platform handles more than 30 billion digital interactions a year, mostly government messages and website visits (Granicus). Its AI agent, **GXA**, answers resident questions 24/7 across web, mobile, text and voice in more than 75 languages (GXA).

The opportunity. GXA answers residents' questions, while agencies can use Granicus tools to send updates and reminders. The opportunity is to connect the two: help residents discover what comes next while they're already asking about a service, instead of relying on them to find each step themselves.

The solution: Proactive Chats. When GXA answers a question about a multi-step service, like the playground project, it can offer the remaining steps from an agency-approved list, with progress tracking and an explanation for each suggestion. Residents can opt into deadline-based reminders by tapping **Remind me.**

The goal: Help residents complete every required step on time, with fewer missed steps and less need to track the process themselves.

Problems

Problem	R	I	C	E	RICE
P1: Residents don't know what steps follow a service	**5**	**4**	**4**	**3**	**26.7**
P2: Predictable follow-up questions add to call volume	5	4	3	3	20
P3: Residents who call or visit in person get no suggestions	2	4	3	4	6

All factors are scored 1–5. RICE = R × I × C ÷ E. For a problem, E is the effort to solve it.

P1 is the priority. It's the problem most directly supported by my survey: 11 of 29 respondents rated their awareness of next steps 1 or 2 out of 5, and 12 of 29 said they'd missed a government step or deadline because they didn't know it existed.

P2 is the potential business case, not a validated outcome. Granicus reports that 50–70% of service-center calls are general-information questions. My hypothesis is that some are repeat questions from residents already navigating a service. The published figure doesn't establish this, so the pilot must test whether proactive guidance reduces repeat inquiries.

P3 is out of scope for this phase. Proactive Chats focuses on residents interacting with GXA directly. Extending next-step suggestions to residents assisted by staff would require a separate workflow within staff-facing tools.

Full evidence is in Appendix A.

Personas

Primary: The Sequential Filer. *"I don't want to find out I missed a step until it's too late."*

- Works through a multi-step process where missed steps cost time or money (fine, delay, re-application).
- Comes to GXA with a question about the task at hand, but must discover subsequent steps independently, often through online searches or friends and family.

Secondary: The Cautious Adopter. *"I'll use this if I understand why it's suggesting something."*

- Wants to understand why a step is recommended before opting into reminders, and expects clear control over reminder frequency and cancellation.
- Turns the feature off if it feels pushy. 16 of 29 respondents share this need for approval first.

Agency user: Service content owner. The staff member responsible for maintaining accurate service guidance. They create and update each service's step list, approve its content and deadlines, and decide which services are eligible for suggestions.

Residents benefit from fewer surprises. Service center staff benefit from fewer repeat calls, but never use the feature directly.

Solution

What already exists. GXA answers resident questions, while Granicus's Targeted Messaging Service sends agency-initiated notices, updates, and reminders by email, voice, or text. Granicus associates these messages with fewer missed appointments and fewer lapsed benefits and licenses (Granicus).

The core experience

- **Agency-approved step lists.** Each participating service has a concise list of next steps written and maintained by the agency. GXA matches a resident's question to the relevant service and uses its approved list rather than generating procedural requirements.
- **Next steps in context.** When relevant, GXA presents the service's steps in order, with a one-line explanation of why each matters. Ex: *"Your outdoor-gym project may need this inspection before it can open."* Residents can track each step as To do, Reminder set, Done, or Skipped.
- **Reminders by choice.** Residents can select an available channel (text, email, or in-chat) and review the reminder schedule before opting in. Each reminder offers Done, Snooze, and Stop actions.

Safety rules. No reminders without explicit consent. GXA presents agency-approved procedural guidance. Agencies can exclude sensitive services, such as health or benefits services, from proactive suggestions.

What's different. Chat-based answers and agency-initiated reminders already exist in the Granicus ecosystem. This concept explores connecting them through contextual next-step guidance, step tracking, and resident-controlled reminders- with explicit consent.

The prototype demonstrates the resident and agency workflows using a fictional town. Feature scoring and rejected alternatives are in Appendix B; the flow and prototype walkthrough are in Appendix C.

Measuring Success

Key metric: Chain Completion Rate. The percentage of residents enrolled in a participating service's step-tracking flow who complete all applicable required steps by their agency-defined deadlines. Define how incomplete, skipped, and agency-confirmed steps are handled before the pilot begins.

- **30 days: Is the guidance relevant?** Track Opt-In Rate and "Not for Me" Rate. Review feedback and service matches to understand whether residents find the suggestions relevant. Test wording and explanation lines before making broader changes.
- **60 days: Does guidance drive action without creating friction?** Track Step Completion Rate alongside Opt-Out Rate, reminder snoozes, and complaints. If completion improves while opt-outs also rise, investigate reminder frequency, timing, and relevance.
- **90 days: Does the experience improve service completion?** Report Chain Completion Rate and Repeat-Contact Rate to stakeholders. If completion improves but repeat contacts do not decline, investigate whether residents are contacting agencies about steps the lists don't cover, or for other reasons unrelated to next-step awareness.

The full metric definitions and guardrails are in Appendix A.

Timeline

Learn before building.

Task	Date
Confirm whether GXA already suggests next steps or supports chat-initiated reminders	Day 0
Assess pilot data: step-completion signals, service volumes, and relevant contact logs	Day 7
Map and validate step lists for 3 services with one pilot agency	Day 14
Test the prototype with 5–8 residents using illustrative playground-project steps and deadlines; validate the flow separately with the pilot agency's approved service lists.	Day 21
Review findings and decide whether to proceed to a pilot; establish build dates after required reviews	Day 30

Build dates depend on accessibility, privacy, records-retention and text-message consent reviews.

Top Risks

GXA may already support some or all of this experience.

- **Mitigation:** Validate existing capabilities with the GXA team before defining the gap. Ask whether GXA suggests service-specific next steps, supports reminders initiated during a conversation, and tracks step completion.

Agencies may not keep step lists current. Incorrect guidance could be worse than no guidance.

- **Mitigation:** Start with three high-volume services per agency. Assign an owner and review date to every list, and provide a "Report a wrong step" option with optional comments.

Reminders could feel like spam.

- **Mitigation:** Require explicit opt-in, default to one reminder per step, combine same-day reminders where appropriate, and include a Stop option in every message. Monitor opt-outs, snoozes, and complaints from the start.

The full risk table is in Appendix E.

Future Steps

- **First:** map step lists with one pilot agency, and count how many repeat calls they'd cover, before building anything.
- **Then:** pilot with 3 services. The pilot shows which steps residents opt into and which lists need rewriting.
- **Phase 2, across agencies:** life changes like a move touch several agencies (address, voter registration, school enrollment). This needs agencies to share step lists, so it waits for Phase 1 results.
- **Phase 3, Staff-assisted service (P3):** Explore surfacing the same approved next steps to staff assisting residents by phone or in person.
- **Later, Data-informed suggestions:** Consider using opt-in and completion patterns to recommend potential steps for agency review, with an explanation shown to residents.

Appendix

A. Evidence & Metrics

Survey method: I surveyed 29 residents of 7 neighborhoods across New York City, Washington DC, Houston, Austin and Chicago in September 2026. I approached people in public places and by phone, and everyone who agreed took part. Every survey figure below is out of 29.

Insight 1: Residents find next steps on their own, often too late (P1)

- 11 of 29 (38%) rated their awareness of related next steps 1 or 2 out of 5.
- 12 of 29 (41%) missed a deadline or step because they didn't know it existed.
- The most commonly reported sources were friends or family (20/29) and independent searches (16/29); 8/29 said the agency informed them.

Insight 2: Simple questions take up a large share of calls (P2)

- 50–70% of calls received by service centers are general-information questions, and average calls last 1.3 to 10 minutes. Source: Granicus, *2026 State of Digital Government* report (Granicus blog).
- Granicus says GXA already cuts call volume by more than 30% (GXA; the method isn't stated on the page). Granicus reports that GXA reduces call volume by more than 30%, though the public page does not specify the measurement method. Proactive Chats will test whether surfacing next steps reduces repeat contacts about participating services.

Insight 3: People want this, but only with consent and restraint

- Average helpfulness rating: 4.17 out of 5 (5 = most helpful).
- 16 of 29 (55%) want to approve before any reminder tracking starts. 10 of 29 (35%) are fine with automatic tracking, and 3 of 29 (10%) have no preference.

- Open-text concerns, grouped:
- **Tone:** "pushy," "sales-like"
- **Frequency:** "spam," "too many notifications"
- **Privacy:** "being watched," "not knowing why it's suggesting something"

Granicus's own principles point the same way. Its published AI/ML principles include *Citizen-Centric Design* and *Transparency and Accountability* (GovTech, May 2025). Opt-in reminders with visible reasons follow both.

Limits of this evidence

- 29 respondents across 5 cities is too few to compare cities, and people who agree to a survey tend to be more engaged than average.
- The call figures cover service centers generally, not GXA users.
- I can see only GXA's public pages. A next-step feature could exist behind a login.

Success Metrics

Goal: Help residents complete every step of a multi-step government service on time. **Key result:** Raise the share of residents who finish all steps in a mapped service without missing a deadline.

Type	Metric	Definition	Why it matters
Key	Chain Completion Rate	% of residents who opt in on a service and finish all its steps by the deadline	Measures the key result directly
Secondary	Opt-In Rate	% of shown next steps where the resident taps Remind me	Are the suggestions relevant?
Secondary	Step Completion Rate	% of reminded steps marked done (agency-confirmed and self-reported shown separately)	Do reminders lead to action?
Secondary	Repeat-Contact Rate	% of opted-in residents who call or chat again about the same service within 30 days	Tests the call-volume case (P2)
Secondary	Channel Split	% of reminders sent by text, email or in-chat	Is one default channel enough?

Guardrail Metrics (to catch side effects)

Metric	Definition	Signals
Opt-Out Rate	% of opted-in residents who stop all reminders	Reminders feel like spam
"Not for Me" Rate	% of shown next steps a resident marks as not relevant	Step lists don't fit real cases
Reminders per Resident per Week	Average messages received	Frequency is creeping up
Wrong-Step Reports	Reports from residents or staff that a step was wrong or outdated	Bad content is eroding trust

B. Choosing the Solution

Solution	R	I	C	E	RICE
Next steps + opt-in reminders	4	4	4	3	21.3
Fully automatic reminders (no opt-in)	5	3	2	2	15
Weekly digest email	4	2	2	2	8
Human outreach team	3	4	3	5	7.2
Agency-approved alerts, sent one by one	3	3	3	4	6.75

Reach is 4, not 5, because only residents who use GXA see suggestions (see P3).

Alternatives considered and rejected

- **Fully automatic reminders.** 16 of 29 want to approve tracking first. More effort doesn't fix a missing-consent problem.
- **Weekly digest email.** Arrives days after the question, when the resident has stopped thinking about the service.
- **Human outreach team.** Costs most effort (E=5), and staff time is what the feature is meant to save.
- **Agency-approved alerts sent one by one.** Lowest score. Staff approve each message, which brings back the manual step this project removes.
- **Machine-learned predictions from interaction data.** No outside data to train or test on, and residents said they want to know *why* something is suggested. Start with agency-written lists, and consider learned suggestions only once there's a history of real opt-ins (Future Steps).

Not in this phase: steps across agencies, suggestions during phone or in-person service, and automatic enrollment.

C. Product Flow & Prototype

The prototype uses a fictional town, Maple Town, with illustrative service journeys based on real-world government processes. The steps and deadlines must be validated with the pilot agency before launch.

Customer Journey

Example service: turning a playground into an outdoor gym in Maple Town. Real steps from each agency.

Stage	What happens
1. Ask	Ask: A neighborhood group asks, “How do we turn our playground into an outdoor gym?”
2. See next steps	GXA shows the five illustrative steps, each with its status, an agency-approved explanation, and a deadline where applicable.
3. Choose	The resident opens a step to see its details and can select Remind me, Already done, or Skip for now.
4. Agree	The resident chooses a channel, reviews the reminder date and consent statement, and confirms.
5. Reminder	The resident receives the reminder and can choose Done, Snooze, or Stop.

6. Close	The step's status updates, and the resident can see the remaining steps.

Prototype Walkthrough

1. **Ask.** Pick a service, or type a question. Typed questions are matched by keyword, and anything else gets the three services to choose from.

Scenario	Steps	What it shows
Add an extra floor	5	A long project, with inspections due next year
Build a place of worship	5	A zoning and site plan review chain
New Year’s Eve Party	5	Deadlines that count back from the real Dec 31
Turn a playground into an outdoor gym	5	The full loop. Play demo runs it by itself in about 30 seconds.

2. **See the list.** Every step shows in order, with its due date and a "Why am I seeing this?" line naming the office that wrote it, plus "Report a wrong step," which takes an optional comment.
3. **Choose.** Opening a step offers Remind me, Already done and Skip for now. A skipped step stays on the list, marked Skipped, and can be reopened.
4. **Opt in.** Remind me shows the channel, the contact, the date of the one reminder, and the consent line before anything is tracked.
5. **Reminder day.** "Skip to reminder day" stands in for time passing. The reminder arrives at the top of the phone with Done, Snooze and Stop. Done updates the list; Stop ends every reminder.
6. **My reminders.** Lists everything opted into, each with its own Stop.
7. **Agency side.** The Agency step lists tab edits each service's list: rename, reorder, add (up to 5) or delete steps, and switch suggestions off. A step with no reason is never shown. Changes appear in the chat right away. Residents’ wrong-step reports, with their comments, appear under each list.
8. **Events tracked.** A side panel logs each event from Appendix E as it happens, so every metric is traced.

D. User Stories, Acceptance Criteria & Edge Cases

User Stories

- As a resident, I want to see the remaining steps in a service, so I can plan and avoid missing any.
- As a resident, I want to know why a step is suggested, so I can trust it.
- As a resident, I want reminders only when I ask, and an easy way to stop them.
- As a resident, I want reminders in the language I chatted in.
- As an agency content owner, I want to write and update each service's steps, so residents only see correct ones.
- As an agency content owner, I want to turn suggestions off for sensitive services.

Acceptance Criteria

- Next steps come only from agency-approved lists of at most 5 steps. Every step shows, in order, with its status. A step never drops off the list because it has a reminder or was skipped.
- Every next step shows a one-line reason and a “Report a wrong step” link. A report goes to the office that wrote the step, with an optional comment.

- No reminder is sent without the resident confirming. Consent is stored with the time, channel and wording shown.
- Every reminder includes Stop. Replying STOP to a text ends all reminders and sends one confirmation. A resident can also stop a single reminder from My reminders or from the step itself.
- Default of 1 reminder per step, sent 3 days before the deadline. Snooze moves it one day, never past the deadline. Reminders due the same day are combined into one message.
- Reminders use the resident's chat language.
- All screens meet WCAG 2.1 AA (screen readers, keyboard use, contrast).
- Only the contact details and steps needed are kept; deleted under the agency's retention policy.

Edge Cases

Prototype = shown in the prototype. *Rule* = decided for the full product; it needs real time, messages or integrations, so the prototype can't show it.

Case	What happens	Shown in
Service has suggestions switched off, or no list	Normal answer, no next steps	Prototype
A step has no reason written	Never shown to residents	Prototype
Resident already did the step	"Already done" marks it done, with no reminder	Prototype
Resident skips a step	No reminder; it stays on the list as Skipped and can be reopened	Prototype
Resident marks "Not for me"	Logged for the agency; stays on the list as Skipped	Prototype
Step has a reminder, resident finishes early	"Mark as done" closes it and cancels the reminder	Prototype
Snooze near the deadline	Moves one day, never past the deadline	Prototype
Step due next year	Date shows the year	Prototype
Agency renames a step	Open reminders use the new name	Prototype
Agency moves a deadline	Open reminders update; the resident is told once	Rule
Deadline already passed	No reminder; shows how to contact the agency	Rule
Anonymous chat	Asks only for the phone or email needed for that reminder	Rule
Message fails to send	Retries once, then shows it in chat on the next visit	Rule
Step belongs to another agency	Shown as an information link only, with no reminder (Phase 1)	Rule

E. Event Tracking & Assumptions/Risks

Events to Track

The prototype logs every event below except Repeat contact, which needs agency call logs.

Event	What it records	Feeds
Next steps shown	Service, number of steps, language	Base for Opt-In and "Not for Me" rates
Reason viewed	Resident opened "Why am I seeing this?"	Opt-In Rate (by reason viewed)
Opt in Reminder	Step, channel, schedule	Opt-In Rate, Channel Split
Step declined	Skip for now or Not for me	"Not for Me" Rate
Reminder sent	Step, channel	Reminders per Resident per Week
Reminder action	Done, Snooze or Stop	Step Completion, Opt-Out Rate
Step completed	Source: agency system or resident	Step and Chain Completion
Chain completed	All steps done by the deadline	Chain Completion Rate
Repeat contact	Call or chat about the same service within 30 days (agency call logs)	Repeat-Contact Rate
Wrong step reported	Who reported it, and which step	Wrong-Step Reports

Assumptions & Risks

Thresholds are my proposals, to be tuned in the pilot.

Assumption	Risk	Mitigation	Act when	Detection metric
It isn't already built behind GXA's login	Pitching something that exists	Ask first (Timeline, Day 0)	Granicus says it exists	—
Agencies will write and maintain step lists	Nothing to suggest	Start with 3 high-volume services per agency; provide starter templates	Fewer than 3 lists live at +21 days	Lists live per agency
A clear reason drives opt-in	Low opt-in	Reason line on every step; test wording	Opt-in under 15% at 30 days	Opt-In Rate
Reminders stay welcome	People opt out	1 per step by default; combine same-day reminders	Opt-out over 10%	Opt-Out Rate
Completion can be detected	Key metric can't be trusted	Use the agency system where connected; report self-reported separately	Under half confirmed by agency at 60 days	Step Completion source split
Next steps reduce repeat calls	Business case fails	Get call logs at pilot start	No drop at 90 days while completion rises	Repeat-Cont act Rate
Step lists stay correct	A wrong step damages trust	Agency-only content; report button; review date on each list	Reports over 1% of steps shown	Wrong-Step Reports

F. Dependencies

Open questions (plus the three under Top Risks)

- Can an agency's systems confirm a step is done, or is self-reporting the only signal?
- Can reminders go out through Targeted Messaging Service?
- How often does an agency's service content change?

To build: step-list storage and editor, next-step display in GXA, the Remind me consent flow, and a reminder schedule with Stop.

To reuse (if available): GXA conversations and language support, Targeted Messaging Service for email and text, and agency service pages as the starting text for step lists.

Reviews: accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA), privacy and records retention, text-message consent rules, and each agency's content approval.

Teams: GXA product and engineering, design, data (event tracking), and agency onboarding.